encountered three unarmed guards. Confronted with the heavily armed group, two of these guards promptly surrendered. One, who put up more of struggle, was injured in the process. The group then picked up the office safe and loaded it on to the back of the jeep and drove down the deserted Avantipora Koil road. The safe contained ₹71,847.60, an astronomical sum in those days. Not surprisingly, the Pulwama dacoity created a sensation and the police went into a tizzy trying to solve the case. They suspected the groups of Kashmir-based Naxalites. In the time the police spent in pursuit of the Naxalites, Zahgir was able to spend the cash without arousing suspicion. He found a piece of land in the village of Barsoo, in the district of Anantnag, which seemed an ideal location for Al-Fatah's new quarters. He spent ₹50,000 or so, to construct a building which was to serve as Al-Fatah's headquarters. Zahgir also rented a house in Srinagar's Buchwara, which served as the political headquarters for the activities of the YML and the SF. The rest of the funds were used to purchase equipment for Al-Fatah; notably, a camera, a tape recorder, a projector for viewing microfilm and a typewriter.

Interestingly, the National Conference had no qualms in permitting the YML and the SF from operating out of these premises. Does one wonder how many senior officials of the National Conference knew what these people were up to?

By May 1970, Zahgir was ready to report on his activities to intelligence officials at the Pakistan High Commission. Accompanying Abdul Hai to New Delhi, Zahgir carried an account of the Pulwama dacoity case as well as some military intelligence data that had been transferred to microfilm. It appears that the cash-strapped high commission had little to offer Zahgir for his efforts. His visit, however, compelled the PIB and the ISI to assess the credibility and efficacy of Al-Fatah.

While PIB's Rathore had not yet been posted to New Delhi, a suspected intelligence operative named Mufti Zia-ul-Haq, a resident of the village of Kreeri, who had left for Pakistan after Partition, visited the valley and held meetings with Zahgir, Nazir Ahmad and Fazl-ul-Haq Qureshi to discuss Al-Fatah's expansion plans. While Al-Fatah was focusing on recruiting new